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ARTICLE

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For a philosophy of comparisons: the problems of comparative studies in relation with Daoism

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ABSTRACT

This paper reflects on the problems of cross-cultural interpretations and translations analysing how these are rooted in theories and philosophical assumptions. Inquiring the concept of philosophy per se, the paper discusses key passages of Heidegger and the related problem of 有 (*you*) and 無 (*wu*). The conclusion is that to translate such terms, it is necessary to revise the coercive onto-theological assumptions of metaphysics. This can trigger a process of re-grounding grounds with the consequent possibility of language transformation, which, in turn, activates new relations between cultural diversities. Thus, philosophy itself becomes an eminently comparative dialogue between cultures. Without setting a single method for all these problems, the paper argues that comparisons themselves call for necessarily different methodological approaches. Hence, whilst Daoism helps to illuminate these issues defining one of the possibilities that a philosophy of comparisons entails, this same reasoning opens a way for another reading of the *Daodejing*.

KEYWORDS

Daodejing; you 有; wu 無; being; Heidegger

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Introduction: what does 'a philosophy of comparisons' mean?

A philosophy of comparisons is not a comparative philosophy—or, at least, not only—and it does not propose a specific method of comparison. Quite the reverse. It philosophises about the comparison and its grounding presuppositions in order to propose a *forma mentis* that allows to enter in the comparative process with a wider perspective. The employment of methods is a step that cannot be taken without theoretical pre-assumptions, either consciously or unconsciously. In fact, 'it is difficult to investigate appropriate methodologies for a field before properly understanding what the field actually is' (Goto-Jones, 2013, p. 138). Therefore, the first aim of a philosophy of comparisons is to explore, revise, expand and transform these pre-assumptions. If it is true that '[c]omparison is the task of philosophy' (Libbrecht, 2009, p. 31), this is because the theoretical discourse needs comparisons in order to set and lay down methods. In other words, through the theoretical comparative discourse one can establish which method needs to be employed in a specific setting. Without a philosophical analysis, methods could not be compared and would be employed uncritically. Hence, a philosophy of comparisons is always a discourse on methods more than a method per se, especially because it presents

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itself as a discourse against univocal methods. Smid (2009) rightly affirms that the 'comparison' of a 'philosophy of comparison' 'refers to the question of how one set of things is understood with respect to another' (p. 3). Clearly, this is something very different from a single method that applies to all the possible comparisons. In fact, one set of things can be understood with respect to another in various ways. As a consequence, a philosophy of comparisons is neither a method nor a meta-philosophy that tries to explain how comparisons 'in general' happen because 'there is no neutral overall birds-eye view from which we could objectively look down at the compared ways of thinking' (Burik, 2009, p. 5). This means that comparisons are always performed from inside the comparative process. Consequentially, such a philosophy asks for a critical analysis of the same concepts and methods employed in comparisons, entailing that each and every comparison needs to revise and re-establish the role of the pre-assumptions in the specific comparative process. And yet, is not this, once more, one of the characteristics of philosophy itself? Should philosophy not always consider its same ground and the ground of what it analyses? If this is true, then a philosophy of comparisons does not propose a single method of comparison because the same philosophy is comparative, that is comparison is the main method employed by this philosophy. On the other hand, the philosophical process is shaped by the comparison itself, which in turn makes specific use of methods depending on the specific elements compared. This entails that, contrary to comparative philosophy where the comparison is the end of the analysis, for a philosophy of comparisons the comparative process is also a means to question, revise, establish, broaden and transform itself as philosophy, that is a process of re-grounding grounds. The outcome of this process depends on what is compared as much as on how the comparison takes place. Goto-Jones (2013) cleverly entitles one of his papers 'What is (Comparative) Philosophy?'. In bracketing 'comparative', it is clear from the outset that his question is, first of all, about philosophy and, only secondarily, about comparative philosophy. Thus, the problem is, once again, to understand what philosophy is. The thesis of this paper is that philosophy ought to be comparative in order to define itself and to understand the other, two aspects that are mutually entailing. Before considering what philosophy means, it is necessary to analyse what a comparison entails from the wider perspective of comparative studies.

The problem of comparative studies

In comparative studies, there is one major problem at the core of the discipline, a problem that every specific comparison needs to take into account: is it possible to interpret across cultural boundaries? This task is generally made more difficult by the use of a different language on the other ground. As a result, the first obstacle that a comparison of cultures needs to overcome is the language barrier. Hence, the interpretation across boundaries is mainly a problem of translation.[1] As a reversal, it is possible to consider translations as specific attempts to compare cultures.[2] Considering the extensive production of past and present translations, it seems natural to affirm that cross-cultural interpretations are possible. Unfortunately, the issue is more complex than this.

As stated by Karl Potter (1989), 'there is a line of thought pioneered mainly by Quine that may seem […] to refute the supposition that any methodology might be devised

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that would (beyond a certain point) enable us to interpret across boundaries' (p. 19). Potter mentions Quine but he is actually referring to the line of thought of his detractors.[3] This reasoning regards Quine's idea of indeterminacy in translation as a failure. In fact, Potter adds that one 'could give the message of this argument by saying that if interpretation across boundaries is possible it is so only in an indeterminate way, that is, that one should not hope for any precise method of interpretation' (p. 20). This *logic* longs for a *scientific method* that can give a precise correspondence of meaning and it presupposes a 'unique equation of meanings' (p. 20) as if translations were equations, as if words were numbers. The problem is that it is not possible to *believe* in a 'determinacy of translation' as if languages were determinate and fixed codes of meanings. There are at least two reasons for this: on the one hand, it is not possible to determine the exact, *true* meaning of a sentence on one side of the boundary and, on the other hand, it is not possible to translate this meaning, once and for all, on the other side.[4] In fact, language is as alive as the culture in which it is employed, it changes as its culture changes and *vice versa*. It is sufficient to see how the character 道 (*dao*) has been interpreted in different ways from the Jesuits until now, from a theist vision to a materialistic experience.[5] This does not imply by any means that a better understanding across boundaries has been progressively achieved in a teleological approach to the *real* meaning. On the contrary, this understanding is always a compromise between the information available from one side of the boundary and the concepts available on the other side. We are not in a better position with respect to the past as well as we are not in a worse position with respect to the future. This 'does not mean that there is no hope in understanding when boundaries are crossed. It only means that once we cross boundaries, we may be required to alter our modes of understanding in order to interpret the signs of another culture correctly' (Allinson, 1989, p. 3).

We shall see how the production of this *alteration* is at the core of this philosophy of comparisons. Yet, what does 'correctly' mean in the words of Allinson? Who is the judge for this correctness and in which epistemological ground is this judgement rooted? Only through the analysis of these questions it is possible to develop a philosophy of comparisons. In fact, if one wants to interpret across boundaries, it is necessary to understand from which standpoint the interpreting process is activated, that is one needs to acknowledge that 'all understanding inevitably involves some prejudice' (Gadamer, 1975/2004, p. 272). The scientific assumption is one of these prejudices. If concepts like 'unique equation of meanings' or 'correctness' are not understood as stemming from specific grounds, the entire attempt at comparative studies is undermined from the outset. If the interpreters approach other cultures only with the idea of understanding the other without considering and enquiring about *their own* understanding, they will continue to reproduce the same mistake of historicism, which

> *despite its critique of rationalism and of natural law philosophy, is based on the modern Enlightenment and unwittingly shares its prejudices*. And there is one prejudice of the Enlightenment that defines its essence: the fundamental prejudice of the Enlightenment is the prejudice against prejudice itself, which denies tradition its power. (Gadamer, 1975/2004, pp. 272–273)[6]

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In the act of interpreting as well as in the act of translating, judgements are employed in two different directions: moving from our standpoint towards other cultures, we transpose our system of thoughts to the other context in the attempt to understand; on the way back, we translate into our system of thoughts what we consider meaningful in what we have understood of the other context. In both cases, while we choose in which direction we move and which concepts we use for our translations, we employ judgements. Consequently, we deploy a set of theoretical justifications when we set out and when we return. Hopefully, this process produces a modification in our system of thoughts; in fact, what 'may seem, in the beginning, like an attempt to understand another culture through our own, in the end may result in a shift in our fundamental way of understanding, which is, in the end, the only way to understand across cultures' (Allinson, 1989, p. 3). Still, in order to perform this shift and, consequently, produce the transformation that a philosophy of comparisons seeks, it is necessary to understand how translations are rooted in theories.

Chad Hansen (1992) asserts that when we consult a dictionary—which is one of the first steps to approach another culture—we assume we are 'learning *the* meaning of a term' (p. 8). This is misleading. According to Hansen, a dictionary 'is an inherited, piecemeal, fragmented interpretive theory' (p. 8).[7] If we accept this perspective, it becomes visible that '[a]n expression has a meaning. Commentaries propose *a theory* of what that meaning is. The dictionary is a theory. A translation of a passage *presupposes* the translator's theory; it is not evidence for it' (p. 10). Moreover, in the act of translating, we do not translate just words, expressions or sentences, but concepts. It is clear, in fact, that if an expression or a sentence has a meaning, this meaning is rooted in a broader context made of a constellation of concepts in relation to other clusters of constellations. The organisation of these clusters is both the reference system[8] that allows the emergence of meaning and the background information that allows translations. When Hansen states that a translation *presupposes* the theory of the translator, he means that, comparing two different cultures, the translator attempts to translate a concept from one system to another. Consequently, in translations—and more generally in comparative studies—one needs to consider the reference systems and the background information of both sides of the boundary. More precisely, on the one hand, it is necessary to compare the relations between meanings and background information at play *within* both sides of the boundary in order to *locate* concepts; on the other hand, one needs to compare these relations *between* the two sides in order to *translate* concepts. Thus, it is possible to consider 'location' and 'translation' as the basic elements of a comparative process.

If we restrict our discourse to the Chinese culture, it is possible to affirm that '[t]he translator needs to take into account not only the meaning of the Chinese words but also the target language of the translation and the audience for whom the translation is intended' (Shankman & Durrant, 2002, pp. 6–7). Insofar as these words are not mere and static words but doors to clusters of concepts, it becomes clear that 'the responsible exercise of comparative Chinese and Western thought requires a combination of philosophical and sinological skills' (Hall, 2002, p. 17). Consequently, 'the translation and articulation of terms such as *dao* 道, *de* 德, *yi* 義, *zhi* 知, among many others, require, by common consent, the use of terms predominantly housed within the Western philosophical tradition' (2002, p. 18). Thus, if the main problem of comparative studies is a

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problem of translation and if in translations we compare not just words but concepts, then the most intimate aspect of this problem is a philosophical one. However, this is not a solution. On the contrary, the philosophical nature of comparisons opens an even more controversial problem: how can we consider philosophy a crucial device in comparative studies if it is rooted only in the ground of the Western boundary's side? Is not the word 'philosophy' a specific concept derived from the Greek φιλόσοφία (*philosophia*) and therefore completely inscribed in the Western tradition? Would it not be another cultural imperialism to impose such a coercive theoretical approach?[9] These issues are crucial and are not confined just to the Chinese context; in fact, the answers to these questions seem to be the first, necessary duty of comparative studies, even if Rorty (1991) warns that

> [w]e should stay alert to the possibility that comparative philosophy not only is not a royal road to intercultural comparison, but may even be a distraction from such comparison. For it may turn out that we are really comparing nothing more than the adaptations of a single transcultural character type to different environments. (p. 8)

The theoretical point is precisely this: to comprehend if adaptations play a necessary part in the process of understanding across boundaries and how this process needs to be considered. If it is true that 'a translation is an interpretive adaptation of an idea in a foreign language' (Cua, 2009, p. 46), it is fundamental to consider the presuppositions for these adaptations. This clearly entails a necessary philosophical analysis. Therefore, as it shall be discussed soon, it is of primary importance to define what 'philosophy' is. In fact, it is only through a more accurate understanding of its ground that it is possible to define a specific standpoint that enables to sharply look at the other side of the boundary as well as to look back at the point of departure when the boundary is crossed.

The problem of φιλόσοφία (*philosophia*)

In *What is philosophy*? (1956/1958), Heidegger explains that when we formulate this question, not only *what* we question but also *how* we question is basically Greek in origin: 'We ask, "what is that?" In Greek this sounds τί ἐστιν [what is it?]' (p. 35). 'What is?' poses the question and, at the same time, gives already an answer. Heidegger explains that the question is about the *essentia*, the essence of something and, at the same time, the *esse*, the being is already affirmed, already implied in the question. This gives the possibility of the philosophy itself insofar as 'the quiddity is determined differently in the various periods of philosophy' (p. 37). In other words, '[t]hat which is asked each time by means of the clues of the τί, the *quid*, the "what," is to be newly determined each time' (p. 37) and, concurrently, what *is* newly determined always affirms the *esse* of the new determination. For these reasons, the history of philosophy is, according to Heidegger, the history of τί τὸ ὄν: what is being?[10]

Therefore, Heidegger concludes that the 'statement that philosophy is in its nature Greek says nothing more than that the West and Europe, and only these, are, in the innermost course of their history, originally "philosophical"' (p. 31).[11] However, few pages later he states that his

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> discussion does not set itself the task of winding up a fixed program. But it would like to prepare all who are participating for a gathering in which what we call the Being of being appeals to us. By naming this we are considering what Aristotle already says. "Being-ness appears in many guises." "Existence is revealed in many ways [Τὸ ὄν λεγέται πολλαχῶς]." (p. 97)

An important—and systematically overlooked—aspect of Heidegger's philosophy is hidden in this passage. In fact, the original German text renders Aristotle thus: 'Das seiend-Sein kommt vielfältig zum Scheinen' (1956/1966, p. 31). Heidegger interprets τὸ ὄν with *das seiend-Sein*[12] which refers to the difference between being as a determined entity and being as such.[13] This forms the so-called ontological difference. Therefore, when Heidegger translates τὸ ὄν with *seiend-Sein*, he presents a philosophy of comparison which interprets in direction of his own philosophy and, in particular, in the direction of the ontological difference. Consequently, Heidegger not only is crossing the boundary with his translation/interpretation, he is also *setting* the boundary, that is to say: he interprets τὸ ὄν through his idea of ontological difference in order to reconsider, realign and explain the entire history of metaphysics as the oblivion of the being as such. Hence, philosophy becomes the history of metaphysics in his 'unthought essence of *esse*' (Heidegger, 1949a, p. 280). And yet, *Sein* remains central: on the one hand, philosophy originates with the question τί ἐστιν and, on the other hand, the question of being as such becomes 'the encompassing question of metaphysics' (Heidegger, 1929, p. 95). This clearly delimits philosophy to a specific cluster of languages. Nevertheless, Heidegger also writes that

> metaphysics belongs to the 'nature of the human being.' […] As long as human beings exist, philosophizing of some sort occurs. Philosophy—what we call philosophy—is the getting under way of metaphysics, in which it comes to itself and to its explicit tasks. (1929, p. 96)

If philosophy is 'the getting under way of metaphysics' and if philosophy as φιλόσοφία is a prerogative of Western culture, how is it possible that metaphysics and philosophy 'belongs to the nature of the human being'? Someone can observe that between 'What is metaphysics?' (1929) and *What is Philosophy?* (1956/1958), the '*Kehre*' happened. Still, how should this 'turn' be interpreted? Should philosophy be read retroactively as metaphysics that belongs to the nature of the mankind enabling everyone to philosophise? Or should metaphysics be considered progressively as philosophy that, being expressly Greek in its root, enables only a delimited cultural group to think metaphysically?

I believe there is a third way. Surprisingly, Heidegger (1943) himself suggests this *other path* asserting that the question 'What is metaphysics?'

> questions beyond metaphysics. It springs from a thinking that has already entered into the overcoming of metaphysics. It belongs to the essence of such transitions that, within certain limits, they must continue to speak the language of that which they help overcome'. (p. 231)

If metaphysics can be overcome, then there is a thinking process outside metaphysics that does not need to be called philosophy or it will be called philosophy only conventionally, without a necessary reference to φιλόσοφία and to τὸ ὄν. If there is a path for philosophy outside metaphysics, then there is a possibility to think without

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being bound to the ontological nature of metaphysics. If this is possible now, it had to be possible also in the past—as it was for Heraclitus[14]—or in other places of the world—as it was in China. If one accepts this rationale, not only the idea of philosophy can be broadened but also the concept of metaphysics itself changes radically, enabling different perspectives. In other words, it becomes possible to encounter the Chinese thought without the restrictions of the Western understanding based on the grounding *subiectum* and its onto-theological nature. This, in turn, allows an ignition of the re-grounding process that a philosophy of comparisons seeks.

The choice to confront the Western's thinking tradition with the Chinese's, and in particular with Daoism, is therefore an opportunity and a possibility to understand, not only if metaphysics can be overcome, but also if metaphysics is a necessary category for philosophy at all.[15] Daoism, in fact, 'may represent a way, not so much of denial of the possibility of philosophical knowledge as such, but rather of letting go of a traditional Western way of thinking in order to reveal an altogether different mode' (Clarke, 2000, p. 175). Daoism may represent 'an alternative way of doing philosophy, one that is "self-transformative" and "orientative" rather than truth-seeking or certainty-seeking' (2000, p. 175). If Daoism offers the possibility to conceive a different way of thinking—to wit, a different philosophising process—the re-grounding of grounds that a philosophy of comparisons seeks emerges precisely from these differences, not as a simple assimilation but as a reciprocal transformation. And yet, even if this transformation is possible, from where one can start the comparative process in order to understand not only Daoism but also one's relation with it? To reply this question, it is necessary to consider the problem of 有 (*you*) and 無 (*wu*).

The problem of 有 and 無

The basic issue that every scholar inevitably faces dealing with Chinese thought is that the verb 'to be', which is 'one of the most striking peculiarities of the Indo-European group' (Graham, 1960, p. 323), has no precise correspondence in classical Chinese. As it has been shown, the metaphysical problems linked to the 'being' are at the core of Western philosophy. In his translation of the important work of Zhang Dainian, *Key concepts in Chinese philosophy* (1987/2002), Edmund Ryden writes:

> [t]he Chinese language does not have any word that correspond to the Greek εἶναι, which is both a grammatical copula and an affirmation of existence. The closest to the verb "to be" is "*you*" [有] which equally well means "to have". (p. 150)

Unfortunately, despite these premises, Ryden translates 有 (*you*) and 無 (*wu*) as Being and Beingless. Therefore, when Zhang quotes the chapter 40 of the *Daodejing*, Ryden translates it thus:

> Reversal is the motion of the Way [道 *dao*]; weakness is the use of the way. The myriad things under heaven [天下 *tian xia*] are generated from being [有]. Being is generated from beingless [無]. (p. 151)

Leaving aside for the moment the first part of the text and its relative problem of *dao*, this translation is highly misleading not only because it follows the inveterate habit to use being and non-being for 有 and 無[16] but also it renders 天下 as 'under heaven',

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giving an even more pronounced metaphysical flavour to the sentence. In fact, the juxtaposition of 'The myriad things under heaven are generated from being' and 'Being is generated from beingless' seem to recall not only the metaphysical assertion '*ex nihilo omne ens qua ens fit* [from the nothing all beings as beings come to be]' but also the Christian proposition '*ex nihilo fit—ens creatum* [from nothing comes—created being]' (Heidegger, 1929, p. 95). As accurately stated by Angus Graham (1960), the verb 'to be' and the verb 有 refer to two different reference systems, making the translation of the Chinese thought with metaphysical concepts extremely problematic (p. 343). In fact, in Chinese

> one approaches existence from something outside, usually undefined, which has, in which there is, the thing in question. […] Western philosophy, grounded in Greek and Latin rather than in ordinary modern speech, has generally approached the question from the opposite direction, from the thing which "is" or "exists". The object of *yu* is the subject of "is". (p. 328)

This is not to say that the early Chinese thought could not conceive any metaphysical perspective. It only means that metaphysics—as conceived in the Western traditions—was not the main focus of classical Chinese language and thought. As clearly asserted by Ames (1991), one 'cannot state the Ontological Argument in Chinese because the language lacks the construction involving the verb "to be" in asserting existence' (p. XII). However, this does not mean that one cannot use 'Chinese as a metalanguage in explaining how the Ontological Argument is something that can be stated in an Indo-European Language' (p. XII). If this is true, we need to be wary not to fall on the other side of the problem, denying to the Chinese philosophy any possibility of abstraction.

Zhang Longxi (1998) voices this danger.[17] He opposes an 'image of China that is nothing but a cultural myth of difference' (p. 110). This is undoubtedly important, we need to avoid any simplistic differentiation as well as monolithic oppositions such as 'the West and the rest'. Differences are present not only within the same tradition but also within the same author or work. Zhang rightly affirms that 'difference is a matter of degree, not of kind' (p. 111). And yet, although differences are certainly a matter of degree, sometimes this degree is so significant that it comes close to a difference of kind. For instance, let us briefly consider the first line of the *Daodejing* from the common version of 王弼 (Wang Bi 226–249) 道可道, 非常道 (*Dao ke dao, fei chang dao*).

This is probably the most problematic of the lines in the *Daodejing* where each character has a meaningful relation with the others. There is no aim to analyse the entire spectrum of its complexity in this context.[18] Only two aspects are worth mentioning here. One is the clear difficulty in interpreting the concept of *dao* per se with its undefined number, gender[19] and its double function of noun and verb.[20] The other is the character 常 (*chang*). Arthur Waley, in his 'attempt to discover what the book meant when it was first written' (1934/2005, p. 13), renders:

> The Way that can be told of is not an Unvarying Way

Here, not only the concept of *dao* is singularised and capitalised as 'the Way' but also 非常(*fei chang*) is translated with the capitalisation of 'Unvarying'. These choices clearly proceed in a transcendental direction. In fact, even if it were possible to accept the capitalisation of 'Way' as a conventional form for concepts, the decision to use a capital letter for an adjective seems to be completely arbitrary. It is evident that Waley considers

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dao as a nominal concept defined by eternal and absolute attributes. This vision resonates in many other translations such as the Lin Yutang's. Although Lin avoids the problem of translating *dao* by the use of its Romanisation, he remains totally inscribed—and probably even more flagrantly—in an onto-theological mindset. His version (1942/2009) abandons any precautions defining *dao* as 'Absolute' in what one can consider the climax of the metaphysical interpretations of the *Daodejing*:

> The Tao that can be told of is not the Absolute Tao

This choice is even more striking if we consider that Lin is against a metaphysical interpretation of early Chinese thought. In the same introduction to his translation, he clearly asks: '[f]or what is the Chinese philosophy, and does China have a philosophy, say, like that of Descartes or Kant, a logically built and cogently reasoned philosophy of knowledge or of reality or of the universe?' (p. XIV). The answer, according to him, is 'proudly "No." That is the whole point. So far as any systematic epistemology or metaphysics is concerned, China had to import it from India. The temperament for systematic philosophy simply wasn't there, and will not be there so long as the Chinese remain Chinese' (p. XIV). Lin seems to go too far in both directions.[21] More recently, Liu (1999) explained that

> some people translate " 常 道 " with "The Absolute Tao". This is not an appropriate translation because "the Absolute" is a peculiar philosophical term of the post-Kantian metaphysical philosophy, it is not by any means employed in the everyday discussion or in the common philosophical debate. (p. 6)

The example clearly shows how metaphysical assumptions are far removed from the Chinese philosophical perspective. This is so not only because 'the Absolute' is a specific post-Kantian concept—as Liu rightly holds it—but also because it belongs to a metaphysical tradition that precedes Kant, going from the unbounded and unreachable Godhood—the *absoluta maximitas* of Nicholas of Cusa—back to the perfect and unchanging Parmenidean being.

We can infer that, yes, differences are certainly a matter of degree but sometimes the degree of differentiation can be extremely difficult to measure. Moreover, if one keeps translating central concepts such as 有 and 無 with 'being' and 'non-being', there will be no chance to even see that a degree of difference exists. If the possibility of concepts' plurality is precluded, the opportunity to learn how to see *differently* is also irremediably lost. The assimilation of 有 and 無 to 'being' and 'non-being' is the assimilation of the Chinese thought to the Western metaphysics. When this move is made, all the other concepts of 道, 天, 常 etc. follow consequently.[22] There is neither understanding nor learning in this process, only repetition. On the other hand, if a distinction between Western metaphysics and Chinese philosophy is posed, this does not mean that the concepts of 有, 無, 道 etc. are undermined. Quite the opposite. The best example in this direction is the one offered by Derrida (1972/1982) when he asks: '[i]s there a "metaphysics" outside the Indo-European organization of the function "to be"?' (p. 199). He replies that

> this is not in the least an ethnocentric question. It does not amount to envisaging that other languages might be *deprived* of the surpassing mission of philosophy and metaphysics but, on the contrary, avoids projecting outside the West very determined forms of "history" and "culture". (p. 199)

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We can conclude, therefore, that translations such as Ryden's or Lin's are highly questionable. It is of little use to acknowledge differences in grammatical structures without considering the concepts reference systems to which they are linked; it is contradictory to warn that the Chinese language does not have any corresponding word to the Greek εἶναι if, afterwards, the very concept of εἶναι is applied to interpret the *Doadejing*. This is misleading with respect to both sides of the boundary. Thus, the main purpose of the translation is missed and the comparison between different cultures or different concepts fails. This automatic repetition and application of unquestioned structures of thought in what ought to be a comparison results in a missed opportunity to learn from the other and, consequentially, to change ossified standpoints re-grounding grounds. On the contrary, the acknowledgment, preparation and transformation of philosophical grounds are prerequisites and consequences of crossing boundaries. This does not avoid the 'ontological relativity' of Quine but helps to thematise it as background theory. In this sense, the Heideggerian '*be-wëgen*' (1985, p. 186) and the Ames/Hall's 'way-making' (2003) try to interpret *dao* transforming their own languages and grounds, overcoming limitations in both directions.[23] In fact, the re-grounding of grounds enables the possibility to establish new relations between differences, which, in turn, *move* the grounds themselves in other directions. The result is a reciprocal transformation that *calls* the others while replying to their summons.

Conclusions: the problem of pseudo-problems

In order to enter in dialogue[24] with the other, it is of primary importance to allow transformations in concepts and languages, activating processes of self-transformations. Similarly, in approaching Daoism, it is necessary to create a space for new words and new concepts in order to welcome other understandings. If this is the basic layer of the comparatist's *forma mentis*, then the problem of philosophy is a pseudo-problem. In fact, although it is always possible to refer to φιλόσοφία for a specific idea developed in a specific time and place, it is also possible to broaden the use of the word 'philosophy' to embrace new concepts. There is no prescription to preserve a word only in its etymology and, although it is necessary to consider the ground where concepts were born, there is no need to freeze a language in an etymological vision. It is imperative not to think of philosophy as a pseudo-problem but as a possibility for comparisons and transformations. This is a necessary step in order to change its language.

Therefore, if philosophy is not a specific result of a determined cultural group, but a 'discipline that involves concepts' (Deleuze & Guattari, 1991/1994, p. 5), the opening of a space for a dialogue between concepts and between systems of reference becomes a philosophical process. This does not mean that, when opened, it will be sufficient to fill this aperture with a few ideas. It is exactly the opposite: the invention—as *in-venire*—of new concepts is needed in order to maintain this opening opened. Through this metaphor, not only it is possible to accept the dialogue with other metaphors, but the dialogue itself is craved as a possibility to transform concepts. 'Philosophers have not been sufficiently concerned with the nature of the concept as philosophical reality' (p. 11). The concept, in fact, 'is not formed but posits itself in itself—it is a self-positing' (p. 11). Surprising enough, this self-positing of concepts and the process of their constant transformation are of great help in order to understand Daoism and *vice*

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versa: if concepts need to be constantly transformed, then the concepts which are followed cannot be part of the constant conceptualisation, so to speak. This is not by any means a mere idealistic process. Quite the reverse. A conceptualisation is always in a reciprocal and co-determined relationship with the experience of the world, participating in a process of aesthetical transformation—after all, in dealing with a multifarious (萬物 *wanwu*) and ever changing world (物化 *wuhua*), it is precisely a matter of being part of it. In fact, 'the myriad things and I are continuous' (萬物與我為一 *wanwu yu wo wei yi*) (*Zhuangzi*, 1947, 5/2/52).[25]

This becomes even more relevant in relation to the second chapter of the *Daodejing* where it is said that 'something and nothing are mutually engendering' (有 無 相 生 *you wu xiang shang*). Here, 'nothing' is not the metaphysical and absolute nothingness but what is yet to come or no longer. In this sense, the mutual engendering process of 有 and 無 refer to forming and un-forming. This implies that not only everything is relational but also that everything is in the constant process of revolving transformation. In other words, the mutual engendering process of the myriad things constantly revolves on itself producing simultaneously something and other than something, that is forming and un-forming.

The *Zhuangzi* (4/2/35–36) explains that things not only are in constant formation but are also constantly dividing because their formation is dissolution and *vice versa*. In its fragmented dissolution, a thing contributes to the formation of a new one and the constitution of this new thing includes the element of the former dissolved one (G. Chen, 2008, p. 218). In this sense, physics and meta-physics are overlapping, provided that the 'meta' of meta-physics recovers the meaning of a temporal 'after'—which implies a 'before'—discharging the transcendent 'beyond'—which implies an 'in itself'. Fragmentation, formation and dissolution are all parts of a continuous process inherent to something (有) and other than something (無) as no longer/not yet, that is to say: a revolving trans-formation of simultaneous forming un-formed and un-forming formed.

Humans participate to this process precisely being in relation with the myriad things. Therefore, if *dao* as way-making needs to be conceived, this is not a subjectivist production, a world-making in the Goodmanian acceptation.[26] Similarly, the *dao* as *bewëgen* should not be regarded as an impersonal 'giving the way', a 'self-withdrawal'[27] not far from the *es gibt* 'it gives'.[28] *Dao* as way-making is neither subjectivist nor impersonal but relational. Way-making is a stream that constantly streams and is streamed because everything actively and passively takes part to it. This implies that one participates to this process not only *with* the world and the others but also *through* them and *vice versa*. Hence, *dao* can be considered as the double movement in which the myriad things find, reach and transform each other.

If such a concept of *dao* can be conceived, this is the first step on an ongoing process that incessantly needs to be prepared in order to be active. The concept, in fact, is itself the invention, the *in-venire*, of a space that allows its self-positing. This concept *belongs* to a dialogue with the other which is intrinsically also a dialogue with oneself, a dialogue intended philosophically as self-positing and self-transforming through the other. By means of this theorising, the cross-cultural endeavour can be undertaken without the bias of having no biases but with the precise intention to open them, use them and make them significant. Employing the fore-structures as pillars of one's system of reference, it is possible to enter in a philosophical dialogue with the other side of the

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boundary trying not only to understand the two different reference systems but also to transform the relations between them. Consequently, philosophy becomes an eminently comparative dialogue between cultures, that is a philosophy of comparisons. From this perspective, the same dialogue with Daoism fosters an aesthetic reconfiguration of concepts, which, in turn, allows the *in-venire* of other language and other understanding. This is the process of re-grounding grounds inherent in the philosophy of comparisons that this paper proposed, a transformation that constantly defines and re-defines itself through the encounter with the world and the other.

Notes

1. This does not mean that the cultural issue is reduced to the linguistic one. However, in an academic context, it is not possible to avoid a certain degree of reductionism. The same term 'culture' is already a reduction. The concept of culture per se is problematic. As Wolfgang Iser (1996) rightly states 'cultures are not clear-cut givens, let alone holistic entities, their encounters inevitably result in mutual molding […] The very fact that mutuality operates the interchange between cultures is due to the structure of culture itself, which is never a "unified text," but is something in the making' (pp. 300–301). It is clear that, if there is the need to specify that 'cultures are not clear-cut givens', then any comparison faces the linguistic problem of defining its object from the outset. As a consequence, if cultures are 'in the making', then also languages need to be in progress. It is not by chance that in Chinese the word for 'culture' is 文化 *wenhua*, a compound of 'language/literature' (originally 'pattern') and 'change'.
2. For a detailed analysis of the translation's problem in comparative studies and how it has always been overcome, cf. Scharfstein (1978). For a philosophical investigation, cf. Derrida (1987).
3. Potter himself clarifies that 'Quine does not say that translation is impossible' (p. 21).
4. See Quine's 'ontological relativity' (1969, p. 26 ff.).
5. For a specific recognition of the reception of Chinese concepts in the West, see Cheng (2002).
6. Emphasis in quotations is always from the original.
7. Dictionaries of the usage are no exceptions, they only show other theoretical stances. See for instance what David Crystal (2009) says in his introduction to Fowler's *A dictionary of modern English usage*. Describing the situation in which Fowler was writing his dictionary, he states that 'Revising his *Dictionary* for final publication in the early 1920s, [Fowler] plainly felt the tension between the traditional focus on a small set of words, pronunciations, and grammatical usages, as indicators of "correct" linguistic behaviour, and the diverse and changing realities of the way educated people actually used language in their everyday lives […] His solid educational background in English grammar, Latin, and Greek was pulling him in one direction; his considerable observational linguistic alertness was pulling him in another' (pp. IX–X). This clearly shows how any choice is always grounded in a specific and, more or less, acknowledged theoretical position.
8. In this context 'system' does not mean a static and unchangeable order but a dynamic flux of interdependent, mutual influencing concepts. For a further analysis of the notion of concept clusters, cf. Ames and Rosemont (2013).
9. For an account of the Japanese formulation of 哲學 *zhéxué* (*tetsugaku* in Japanese) as a translation of φιλόσοφία and its acquisition in China, cf. Cua (2009, pp. 44–45) and Tang (2007). For a definition of 'sage' in the Chinese tradition, cf. Shankman (2002). See also the Defoort–Raud debate on Chinese philosophy in *Philosophy Est and West* 2001 (vol. 51 n. 3) and 2006 (Vol. 56 n. 4).
10. Heidegger is referring to Aristotle who 'characterized this step by the following statement: […] "And thus, as was in the past, is now too and will be ever more, that towards which

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(philosophy) is moving and to which it again and again does not find access, is (the question raised)—what is being? (τί τὸ ὄν)"' (1956/1958, p. 53).

11. It is not possible in this context to discuss Heidegger's contradictory assertions about the Greek origins of philosophy and his interest in the concept of *dao*. For an extensive analysis of the Heideggerian connections with Daoism, cf. Ma (2008).
12. For an account of Heidegger's intentions regarding this translation, cf. Sheehan (1978, p. 288).
13. For a grammatical analysis of the *Sein* and *seiend* and their relation to the Heideggerian ontological difference, cf. Inwood (1999, pp. 26–27). Almost as a remark on the importance of these terms, in the first note of *Heidegger (1927/1962)*, Macquarrie and Robinson specifically discuss them (p. 19). Commenting a passage of *Being and Time*, Barbara Cassin (2014) explains that 'one of the main difficulties in standard English is that *Sein* (infinitive) is normally translated as "Being,"—that is to say, already a present participle. How then shall we distinguish between *Seiend* (*étant*, "being") and *Sein* (*être*, "Being")? The solution adopted by Macquarrie and Robinson is to translate the present participle *seiend* using "entity"/"entities" (the difference between singular and plural in the English translation seems arbitrary), and to maintain Being for *Sein*. Two problems then arise: 1. The so-called ontological difference *Sein/seiend, être/étant* is no longer recognizable in the word pair "Being"/"entity." 2. It is difficult to maintain the translation "entity" when Heidegger underlines the present participle and the presence of the present in it' (p. 1209).
14. Heidegger himself considers Heraclitus pre-metaphysical. Cf. Heidegger & Fink (1970/1979), pp. 64–76).
15. For an analysis of the relation between Daoism and metaphysics, cf. Cheng (1989). For a radical questioning of the metaphysical nature of Daoism, see Burik (2010).
16. According to Ma (2008) 'Although in the past the Chinese words *you* and *wu* have in fact often been translated as Being and Nothing, there has been a consensus that they cannot be identified with Western philosophical notions' (p. 6). Even if this were the case, this 'consensus' would not prevent misleading translations as we have just seen.
17. Among others, Zhang openly criticises the position of Ames and Hall. For a reply, cf. Ames and Rosemont (2013, p. 29 ff.).
18. For a detailed analysis of this first line, see my forthcoming article 'Interpreting *Dao* 道 between "Way-making" and "Be-wëgen"' In G. Bracken (Ed.) *City and Society: The Care of the Self*. Volume I. *Ancient and Modern Practices in East and West*. Amsterdam: Amsterdam University Press, 2018.
19. Chad Hansen clarifies how the use of the article and capitalisation of *dao* 'embodies an ancient interpretive hypothesis that all Daoists must worship a mystical godlike *dao*. Thus they presume in translation what they cannot find in the original: Assertion of the existence of a single, ineffable *dao*' (1992, p. 215).
20. 'With respect to its etymology, *dao*, as a noun, originally meant "way leading in a direction"; as a verb, *dao* means "guiding to go," consisting of the dual meaning of "guidance" and "move." Obviously, "guidance" has certain direction. "Move" means "march" or "go forward"' (L. Chen, 1999, p. 13).
21. For a specific analysis of the possibility to have a philosophy with no substance and no ontological status, see Xinyan (2002).
22. It goes without saying that the problem of translation is not just a Western issue or a problem confined to the past. It is a contemporary problem for both sides of the boundary. See, for instance, Chen (1999, p. 11) or Chen (2004, p. 72) and their concerns to employ Western philosophical language in relation to Chinese classics.
23. This does not mean that these translations are unproblematic. On the one hand, the idea of way-making should be confronted with the Goodman's worldmaking. Although Ames and Hall do not refer to it, in another context, Ames mentions this idea stating that: '*dao* references the human sojourn through the life experience and might alternatively be translated as "world-making" with the understanding that the etymology of the term "world" is literally "the age of man"' (2015, p. 264). The problem with worldmaking is that

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it seems not far from the Western modern understanding of the subject as *subiectum*, which in turn is the grounding substance (*sub-stare*, to stand under) that objectifies the world. On the other hand, *be-wëgen* needs to be evaluated in the context of the Heideggerian philosophy which constantly brings back the discourse on being making the concept totally impersonal. In fact, *be-wëgen* has a similar function to the one of *es gibt* 'it gives' insofar as 'We hear the words "give way" (*Be-wëgung*) in this sense: to be the original giver and founder of ways' (Heidegger, 1957–1958, p. 92). We shall come back to this in the conclusions.

24. Dialogue here does not have any dialectical implication; it only points to linguistic relations and exchanges as those that one can easily find in the *Zhuangzi*.
25. On the idea of *yi* as continuity, see Ames (2015, p. 266) and Coutinho (2014, p. 64).
26. See, for instance, how Goodman's aim is not only towards a pluralistic but also subjectivist 'creation and comprehension' of worlds (1976, p. 265).
27. This is the interpretation of Stenstad (2006, pp. 80–81), one of the few scholars who acknowledges the importance of the concept of *be-wëgen* in the Heideggerian philosophy.
28. See on this the well-known passage in Heidegger (1949b, pp. 254–255).

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